mound') since Devi was the daughter of a merchant, this being a characteristically Vaishya occupation.



Fig. 4.3: Ujjayini's Kanipura stupa which is associated with Devi

Beyond the Buddhist associations, the way in which Devi is described in the Pali texts suggests she followed this relatively new faith. Unlike Ashoka, or even her own children, there is no mention at all of her having *converted* to it. In fact, her portrayal in the *Mahavamsa*, where she is shown —much after the time period that forms the focus of this chapter—as leading her son Mahinda, by then a monk ('thera'), 'up to the lovely vihara Vedisagiri', suggests that she was already a Buddhist and strongly associated with that vihara. Because this was on a hill, the conjecture is that the monastery where the mother chose to take her monk-son and his companions was Sanchi. This happened, of course, much after Ashoka's early years, but the incident is worth looking at here in order to make the